

Complex Tense Forms

Tense implies the use of a verb, phrasal verb or verb phrase to show the time of an action or to show the state expressed by such a verb or phrasal verb or verb phrase. It also implies using a verb, phrasal verb or verb phrase to show continuance of action or the completion of the action expressed by such verb.

TYPES OF TENSES

- 1) The simple present tense
- 2) Present continuous tense
- 3) Present perfect tense
- 4) Present perfect continuous tense
- 5) Simple past tense
- 6) Past perfect tense
- 7) Past perfect continuous tense
- 8) Future tense

THE SIMPLE PRESENT TENSE:- It is used to express habitual actions, general truths or statements. Examples (i) The word is spherical (ii) The students are taught by qualified teachers (iii) The pastor preaches the truth (iv) She comes to visit us every weekend.

PRESENT CONTINUOUS TENSE:- This indicates that an action is still on at the time of speaking or waiting. A primary auxiliary verb is used with the – ing form of the main verb. Examples: (i) The teacher is teaching now (ii) The students are being taught (passive words)

PRESENT PERFECT TENSE:- This shows that an action which started and was completed in the past still has a link with the present. In this case, the modal auxiliary verbs- has and have are used with the participle form of the main verb. Examples: (i) The boy has passed the test (ii) He has warned the teacher to mind his business.

Present perfect tense also indicates that an action which started in the past has not been concluded. Examples: (i) My husband has gone to church (He left sometime in the past and has not returned as at the time of speaking or event) (ii) The plane has arrived (It is still at the airport)

PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS TENSE:- This expresses an action that began in the past and is still continuing. It shows that an action has not been concluded.

Examples: (i) I have been teaching for ten years (ii) He has been building his house since last year.

SIMPLE PAST TENSE:- This shows that an action started and was completed in the past. It also indicates a past habit which the person being referred to is no more involved in.

Examples: (i) I was employed in 1991 (passive voice) (ii) He used to travel home when he was young (has stopped travelling home). Etc

The teacher guides the students in explaining the complex tense as she directs their attention to the instructional resource.

The complex tense form has more than one verb. This verb will always have an auxiliary verb (helping verb) and the main verb.

Auxiliary verbs include:

Be – is, are, am, was, were, being, been

Have – has, had

Do – does, did, done

These verbs can also be the main verb in a sentence, as in!

- Ade is a good student
- He did his homework
- He had his bag

The auxiliary verbs also help us to form a negative or a question. Examples –

She went to school-> she did not go to school.

simple tense	verb	main verb.

Did she go to school?

auxiliary	main verb
verb	

Another set of auxiliary or helping verbs we use to form complex tenses are modal verbs, which are always used with other verbs to express possibility, ability, permission, necessity, willingness or advice or obligation. Examples:

You can sit down now

Modal	main
Auxiliary	verb

I could dance for two hours some years ago.

Pass	main verb
Tense	

ASSIGNMENT:- Complete the following sentences using the simple (present or past) and the continuous (present or past) tense forms.

- a) Wole Soyinka – the novel many years ago (write)
- b) The laundry man – the curtains when they came in (wash)

- c) The new students – noise always (make)

REFERENCES

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